

The Death OF DIGNITY

Political discourse has touched an all-time low with verbal pugilists from all parties playing it dirty and personal. Skullduggery is in vogue and civility is on the wane. All that matters is shrillness and silliness.

■ By Prabhu Chawla

Being a weatherman of politics, I can say this much as I write this on a cold morning in the New Year: winter in Lutyens' Delhi was less chilly 25 years ago. It was 1982 and the occasion was a formal lunch hosted by the then prime minister Indira Gandhi for the visiting French president Francois Mitterrand. In the small gathering of invitees was BJP leader Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Indira introduced the right winger, known for his gift of the gab, to the imposing socialist as the man "who makes my life miserable in Parliament". She didn't forget to tell her guest that Vajpayee was "one of our outstanding parliamentarians". It was a lighter moment steeped in rare political dignity between three exceptional politicians.

Even in the traumatic aftermath of the Emergency, there was a sense of political civility. In 2007, however, our politicians were in no mood to extend courtesies to their colleagues. Not only has the body language of our leaders become much more aggressive and, occasionally, outright obnoxious, it also indicates the ominous clash of outdated ideologies. Look at the language used by the gentleman Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, BJP's next prime ministerial candidate L.K. Advani, the newly iconic Narendra Modi, Dalit diva Mayawati, Dravidian patriarch M. Karunanidhi, awesome amma J. Jayalalithaa, Telugu moderniser N. Chandrababu Naidu, and the irrepressible Lalu Prasad Yadav, against their adversaries. It appears as if they are participating in a demagoguery competition where all that matters is shrillness and silliness.

Here are some samples. Sonia Gandhi, in a sudden outburst of poetic demonology, labelled Modi and the entire Gujarat leadership of BJP as "merchants of death". Modi, masculine Hindutva's most acerbic tongue, was quick to retort, questioning Soniabehn's national commitment. Quite uncharacteristically, Manmohan saw Advani's anointment as the next BJP prime

ministerial candidate as a desperate measure prompted by the rise of Modi. Advani, on his part, dismissed the prime minister as a weakling and a political cipher.

An unofficial social segregation prevailed in the political arena. There was a time when wishing top opposition leaders on their birthdays or attending their children's weddings was normal. No longer. Well, the prime minister did indeed wish both Advani and Vajpayee on their birthdays and they returned the favour. No such cordiality exists between Sonia and the BJP leadership though. Even leaders like Lalu and Ram Vilas Paswan don't think it appropriate to join their rivals in their happy moments. They are getting more and more vindictive. The security cover of former Tamil Nadu chief minister Jayalalithaa was considerably scaled down when DMK came to power. In Uttar Pradesh, too, Mayawati ordered the withdrawal of security provided to various Samajwadi Party leaders because she had got a shoddy treatment from the Mulayam Singh government earlier.

The politics of confrontation is so blatant that adversaries do not share the same platform on social functions. Have you seen Jayalalithaa and Karunanidhi together on a stage in the last 15 years? It took three years for Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy and his rival Naidu to share a stage (organised by INDIA TODAY). One rarely finds Advani and Sonia on the same platform.

With the personal rapport between various leaders fast disappearing, it has become fashionable for politicians to ask their thought providers and speech writers to come up with the most venomous details about their adversaries. Such skullduggeries are meant to demolish reputations and influence the electorate. Earlier, only low-rung politicians resorted to such trickery. Now ideological offensive is on a retreat and personal assault is in vogue. These dishonourable verbal pugilists have devalued the art of political discourse.

It was a cultural shift in the idea of leadership